

Fill 'er Up!

I'm running out of hard drive space, and fast

We at Digit often become victims of storage concerns—we stockpile our DVD content, which inevitably led to a sudden dearth of storage space. A trip to Lamington Road was in order: we needed to pick up a couple of large hard drives, as well as an external 2.5-inch solution.

A 2.5 inch notebook HDD is the *de facto* preference for any sort of portable usage because they function with just a USB connection and don't require an additional power connection like their 3.5 inch siblings—which are also bulkier. When hunting for a portable drive, you can either buy an external solution from Transcend or Western Digital, (the two most widespread brands), or you can buy a notebook hard drive and a separate external chassis for it. Such a chassis is available from brands like Transcend (Rs 700), to smaller brands like Zippy and Tech-Com (as low as Rs 200). I also saw an E-SATA external from Zippy, priced at Rs 800, although this doesn't feature USB. Notebook hard drives themselves are available from Hitachi and WD priced nearly identically, with WD enjoying a small premium in the range of Rs 200 over Hitachi. The prices of Hitachi's 80, 120 and 160 GB 2.5 inch HDDs are Rs 1,950, 2,400, and 2,850 respectively. For larger sizes 250 and 320 GB HDDs are available from WD for Rs 4,200 and Rs 6,500. A better option according to me is to simply buy a readymade external solution like Transcend's StoreJet series or WD's My Passport series. Of the two I prefer WD solutions for being more dependable as well as better looking. They also have an Elite series, which features a bet-

ter finish, a capacity gauge, auto sync and data encryption, automatic data backups and remote access software, although these command a premium of around Rs 3,000 over the regular WD series of the same storage capacity. A 160 GB WD My Passport drive costs around Rs 3,200, while the 250 GB version is priced at Rs 4,600. The 320 GB version is priced at Rs 6,650 and makes sense for only monstrous data hogs. Comparatively, Transcend's solutions are available in capacities of up to 250 GB, and the prices are around Rs 400 less than WD.

For the 3.5 inch solutions, the market leaders are Seagate and WD (not in that order).

Now for the prices—the new Seagate 500 GB 7200.11 series, with 32 MB of buffer was available for as low as

ing is something new, and built using two 320 GB platters offers one of the highest areal densities available, and is a stunning performer. At Rs 4,600 its very affordable for someone looking for a high-end PC this is a must buy. WD also has a 750 GB offering, that although a bit slower than their 640 GB version offers 110 GB more storage for a mere Rs 900 more (Rs 5500). Seagate has a 750 GB offering of their own, which is supposed to be as fast as the WD 640 GB drive but much costlier at Rs 6,500—not worth the Rs 1,000 premium. 1 terabyte drives have also arrived with WDs 1 TB version costing Rs 9,100, and Seagate 7200.11 series costing around 9,550, although very obviously price per GB is not in favour of such drives, and buying

two 500 GB HDDs makes more sense monetarily. WD does have a fast performance series titled *black* (the other two families of drives being blue and green series), however the black series available in only 750 GB and 1 TB capacities with caches of 32 MB wasn't

available in our markets at the time of my visit. Maxtor and Hitachi aren't selling much, therefore prices aren't too competitive. I did get the pricing of a Hitachi 750 GB—Rs 6,000.

The cost per GB of the WD 6400AAKS is the lowest (best) at Rs 7.19, while the WD 7500AAKS comes second at Rs 7.49. Seagate's nearest entrant is their 500 GB 7200.11 series at Rs 7.8 per GB. The 1 TB drives are totally not worth the premium you pay for the extra 250 odd GB.

I picked up 2 WD 7500AAKS drives (blue versions)—1.5 terabytes of storage ought to be enough for now, and speed wasn't really that important since these were for backups. I also chose the WD My Passport 160 GB from the same vendor. I managed to get the lot for Rs 13,200. For personal use, I'll wait for the prices of the Seagate 750 GB to fall; that, and the entry of the WD Black series. ☐

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Rs 3,900—amazing! WDs own 500 GB (WD5000AAKS) was available for as low as Rs 3,650, although the Seagate is much faster. The slim 250 GB Seagate (7200.10 family) was available for as low as Rs 2,300, and with a single platter, this HDD is cool and fast—ideal for gaming PCs or even HTPCs. WD's 320 GB (WD3200AAKS) is also available for Rs 2,750 and is an alternative to the 250 GB Seagate. Their 250 GB offering is a mere Rs 2,400, but the cheaper Seagate 250 GB is also much faster, so this one is largely redundant. WDs 640 GB offer-

HDD Price Per GB

Brand	Model No	Size (GB)	Price	Cost Per GB (Rs)
Seagate	7200.11 ST31000340NS	1000	9,550	9.55
Seagate	7200.11 ST3750330NS	750	6,500	8.67
Seagate	7200.11 ST3500320AS	500	3,900	7.80
Seagate	7200.10 ST3250620NS	250	2,300	9.20
WD	WD 7500AAKS	750	5,600	7.47
WD	WD 6400AAKS	640	4,600	7.19
WD	WD 5000AAKS	500	3,650	7.30
WD	WD 2500AAKS	250	2,400	9.60